Plinko: development plan

Build Queue 243 to 246, 2026-10-20. Modeled on Baamboozle's Plink-oh, built our way: questions first, iPad first, read aloud, no em dashes.

> **Her words:** "1 - the design of our plink needs to be modeled after Baamboozles Plink-oh game. 2, questions should alwyas pop up in our native regular way, drop zones selected after. power ups should show on the right side, score board on the left. 3- multiplayer game." "I want to make this game with customizable theme/designs ... a pdf file (or image files) that can be downloaded, uploaded to canva, and added ... they can then be selected at the main menu screen after i upload the theme as a teacher."

Where it is today

- Plinko Drop: one player. The four answers label four chutes at the top; dropping down the right chute sends the ball through the pegs into a ticket slot (2, 5, 1, 3, 10, 3, 1, 5, 2). Tickets buy carnival plushies at the Prize Counter; $1 Class Cash per right answer.
- Start card with a "Drops this game" slider (5 to 20).
- What changes: the answer is no longer the drop chute. The question comes first, in the normal question pop-up, and only a right answer earns a drop.

The new game, screen by screen

1. Main menu (Plink-oh setup screen)

- Big themed title (the theme's title image), three big sliders: **Players** (1 to 4), **Questions** (how many drops in the whole game, shown as "8 each"), **Game time** (off, 3, 5, 10 minutes).
- **Theme picker:** a row of theme covers (Carnival, Winter, Dogs, and every theme she uploads). The picked theme dresses every screen.
- Next goes to Players. Same settings card rules as every game (her assignment can lock them).

2. Players

- One big ball per player, each in its theme ball picture, with a name button: the student's own name for player 1, then classmates typed or picked, or a Neighbor (Phase 2). Random shuffles who goes first.

3. A turn

- **Question first:** the native question pop-up (the same one every game uses: read aloud, the 3-second read first pause, toolbox, one try).

- **Right answer:** the drop board opens. The ball slides along the top; the student taps a drop zone (or drags the ball and lets go). Plink-oh style board: tall, about 6 columns of pegs, a few bonus pegs, four big score buckets at the bottom (10, 30, 20, 40, order shuffled every round).
- **Wrong answer:** the right answer shows and the turn passes (Skip, like Plink-oh). No drop, no points.
- **Left side: scoreboard.** Every player's ball, name and score, a crown on the leader, "Round 2 of 8" at the bottom.
- **Right side: power-ups.** A card shows the power-up this turn earned (about one in three right answers), with Use and Save buttons.

4. Power-ups (first set)

Power-up	What it does
Double	This drop's bucket counts twice.
Big Ball	A bigger ball that bounces less, easier to aim.
Magnet	Pulls the ball toward the 40 bucket.
Second Drop	Drop a second ball.
Swap	Trade scores with the leader (multiplayer only, once a game).
Freeze	The next player's buckets are all 10 (multiplayer only).

Bonus pegs on the board (like Plink-oh's stars): touching one adds 5 points. Nothing is ever taken away from a student for a wrong answer.

5. End

- Podium with every player's ball and score, confetti, the winner read aloud. Class Cash goes to the logged-in student ($1 per right answer, as today). Tickets and the Prize Counter stay.

Phases

Phase	What ships
1 (Build Queue 244)	New layout (scoreboard left, board middle, power-ups right), question pop-up first then pick the drop zone, Plink-oh board with 4 buckets and bonus pegs, the 6 power-ups, the setup screen with sliders, the built-in Carnival theme. One player.
2 (245)	Multiplayer on one iPad: 2 to 4 players or teams take turns, each with their own ball and score; "Pass the iPad to Ava" screen between turns; a Neighbor can be a player (it answers on its own, using its personality); the game joins the 2+ player list so Neighbors can be invited.
3 (246)	Custom themes: the Canva theme kit, a Theme manager for the teacher (upload pieces, preview, release), theme picker on the menu, Winter and Dogs starter themes.

	Student-made themes come through the teacher (she uploads them after looking).
Later	Online multiplayer across iPads with a 4-digit join code (like the Gus live share), seasonal themes that switch on by date, a theme contest.

Custom themes: how it works

Making a theme (teacher or students)

- Download the **Plinko theme kit** (Question Sets → Plinko themes, or *docs/plinko-theme-kit*): one PDF with a page per piece at its exact size, plus the same pages as PNGs.
- In Canva: Create a design → Import file → pick the PDF. Each page opens at its right size with guide boxes. Design over the guides, then delete the guide layer.
- Download each page as PNG (tick "Transparent background" for the peg, balls and title; that box needs Canva Pro or Canva for Education, which is free for teachers).

Piece	Size (pixels)	Needed?
Background	2048 x 1536	Yes
Board (backboard behind the pegs)	900 x 1250	Yes
Peg	128 x 128, transparent	Optional (plain pegs in the theme color)
Balls 1 to 4 (one per player)	256 x 256, transparent	Ball 1 yes, others optional
Bucket	300 x 220	Optional (colored buckets)
Title	1600 x 480, transparent	Optional (the name in big letters)
Side panel	600 x 900	Optional
Cover (theme picker card)	1600 x 900	Yes

Adding it to the game (teacher)

- Teacher → Plinko themes → New theme: name it, drop in the PNGs (or one zip of them), pick 4 bucket colors and a text color, see a live preview of the real board.
- Save keeps it as a draft; **Release** puts it on every student's theme picker. Hide or delete any time. Themes are saved in the app (no SQL for her to run).

Claudia's checks (high support learners)

- Read first: questions come before any aiming, so a student cannot win by tapping fast. The 3-second pause applies.

- Aiming is easy for every motor level: tap a drop zone (no precise drag needed), Big Ball helps.
- Turn taking is clear: whose turn it is shows in the player's ball color and is read aloud.
- Themes must keep the ball and buckets easy to see: the preview warns when the board is too busy or text is hard to read.
- iPad first: big buttons, both orientations (in portrait the scoreboard and power-ups sit above and below the board).

Questions for her

- Should a wrong answer pass the turn (Plink-oh) or give one more try for half points?
- Keep tickets and the Prize Counter, or only points and Class Cash?
- Can students upload their own themes straight from their account, or always through her? (Plan: through her.)